



ChessGoals Study Plans

Let us help you reach chess master!

Intermediate Adult Improver Plan

Aimed for adults rated 1100-1699 looking to make efficient chess progress. Can be alternated with the Intermediate Yusupov Plan.

Study Plan Layout

This is going to be a 12-week study plan that is intended to recommend an exact plan for you to follow.

- You can always do more than the plan proposes, just keep an eye on burnout.
- If you are short on time one week don't sweat it. Focus on getting back on track the next week.
- Switching days around within the week is fine, but try not to let tasks carry over from week to week.
- Stick with the plan for the full 12 weeks to give it time to work, even if you graduate out of the Intermediate category.

Questions? Please ask in the [ChessGoals Discord](#) server study plan channels.

Yusupov Intermediate vs. Adult Improver Intermediate Study Plans

Here are the differences between the two plans. If you prefer to study more than 20%, choose the Yusupov Intermediate Plan.

Time spent: 7+ hours per week, more is always better as long as burnout is avoided. This plan is based on approximately 7-10 hours per week, which is similar to the Yusupov Intermediate Study Plan. If you can put in more time, look to complete the bonus items each week.

Players completing the basic work average ~130 points annually, and full bonus work ~200 points.

Playing vs Studying: Optimally, 80% of chess time is spent playing games. Even though it feels like there's almost no time studying, give this a try for the full 12 weeks. The data shows that intermediate adults spending 60% of the time playing average only 55 points annual rating gain. This plan is to maximize gains as an intermediate adult!

Day 0: Getting Started

Note: see the alternatives section on the next page for alternative options for chess.com and the recommended book.

1. Setup a chess.com membership if you do not have one already.
2. Join the [ChessGoals Club](#) on chess.com and introduce yourself to the community. Let us know how you found ChessGoals.
3. Join the [Discord](#) server and introduce yourself. Use the study plan channels to ask NM Matt Jensen your questions.
4. Start 5 [Daily games](#). Daily games are games that you have 1-3 days to make each move. You will be checking these games each day.
5. Log your ratings here:
 - a. Chess.com Blitz _____
 - b. Chess.com Rapid _____
 - c. USCF _____ (if applicable)
 - d. FIDE _____ (if applicable)
6. Think about a resource you already have, or would like to use for each of the following tasks
 - a. Woodpecker Method: _____
 - b. Strategy Review: _____
 - c. Opening Review: _____
 - d. Endgame Review: _____
7. Familiarize yourself with the Chess.com site
 - a. [ChessGoals Club](#)
 - b. [Live chess](#)
 - c. [Lessons](#)

Resources and Alternatives

Woodpecker Method: The book can be purchased on [Amazon](#) or [Chessable](#). Other tactics books or websites can be used.

Strategy: Lots of good options here. If you already have a strategy book you enjoy go with that. [Reassess Your Chess](#) is the top book recommendation. Chess.com strategy [lessons](#) are also very good.

Endgame: Select a book from the [Top 3 Endgame Books](#), or use Chess.com lessons.

Openings: Lots of options, see Tasks Explained.

Alternatives

Some of our recommendations involve books or chess.com premium features. Here we will list some alternatives for those looking for different options or to save money.

Chess.com membership

- Daily and live games -> lichess.org
- ChessGoals club -> <https://www.reddit.com/r/chessgoals/> (very inactive)
- Discord -> email matt@chessgoals.com with questions

Books

- Silman's Endgame Course -> It's recommended that everyone purchase one endgame book. The [3 Best Endgame Books](#) will last a lifetime, unlike opening/middlegame books that can become outdated.
- Woodpecker Method -> chesstempo.com or lichess.org

Tasks Explained

☀ **Daily Games:** Spend approximately 5 minutes per move. Since there is no clock, try to think critically about each move. This is where you can apply what you've learned in strategy lessons. Downloading the chess.com app is an easy way to make your chess moves anytime throughout the day. If you can make a move on each game when it's your turn each day, that is perfect. After each game finishes go into analysis mode and think of two positive takeaways and two takeaways to improve on.

⌚ **Rapid Games:** To be played at a 15+10 time control or slower. These games can be replaced by over-the-board (OTB) rated events like USCF or FIDE. After each game finishes go into analysis mode and complete **game analysis**.

⚡ **Blitz Games:** To be played at a 5+5, 3+2, or 3+0 time control. Optional: after each game finishes go into analysis mode and complete **game analysis**. [Can blitz make you a better chess player?](#)

Game Analysis: Retry mistakes or look at key moments after each game in analysis mode. Take advantage of the site's analysis features, whether on chess.com or lichess.org. After each game, tell yourself *two* positive and *two* constructive takeaways. You either win or you learn, and when you win you also learn. More tips on game analysis - <https://chessgoals.com/game-analysis/>

Woodpecker Method: The book can be purchased on [Amazon](#) or [Chessable](#). Here are the main points of the Woodpecker:

1. Go through a set of problems and retain the order
2. Go back through the same set of problems, looking to improve your solving time and accuracy
3. Repeat steps 1-2

If you are getting faster or have extra time, add more puzzles to the end of the set.



Chess.com Puzzles (can replace Woodpecker):

Work your way through the regular puzzles. When you get a puzzle incorrect, try it a second time. If still incorrect, try to really understand why the answer works. This will build your pattern recognition over time and is very important. You can also use [puzzle rush](#) or [puzzle battle](#) for this section.

 **Chess.com Lessons (Strategy Option):** This will be at your own pace, but try to stick to our recommended time allotments. Work your way through the lessons in order.

Silman's Endgame Course: Use your physical board to practice the endgame positions. Work through the chapters slowly.

 **Openings:** The least important item to study for intermediate players. If you have a chess.com premium membership there are some good lessons on openings. Free options include [Opening Explorer](#) and [St. Louis Chess Club Youtube channel](#). ChessGoals is building an opening repertoire based on [Best Openings For All Skill Levels](#) and the first repertoire is the [Caro-Kann](#).

Week 1

Start each day with your daily games. Start a [new forum topic](#) titled “X’s Intermediate Adult Improver Plan” and replace X with your name. Once you are complete with the base work for the day, move to the extra credit. Introduce yourself on the Discord server.

	Base Work	Extra Credit
Day 1	☐ Start study plan post ☐ Daily games [see tasks explained] ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	<u>In order of Priority</u> ☐ Slow Game 1 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 1 ☐ Woodpecker Method ☐ Slow Game 2 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 2
Day 2	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 3	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 4	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 5	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 6	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 7	☐ Woodpecker Method ___ min (track time spent)	

If there’s still time after the above, add more daily games or slow games.

Week 2

Openings this week and push to complete some extra credit.

	Base Work	Extra Credit
Day 1	☐ Update study plan post ☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	<u>Complete in order</u> ☐ Slow Game 1 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 1 ☐ Woodpecker Method ☐ Slow Game 2 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 2
Day 2	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 3	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 4	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 5	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 6	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 7	☐ Opening Review ___ min (track time spent)	

If there's still time after the above, add more daily games or slow games.

Week 3

Try to start implementing ideas learned from reviewing your games.

	Base Work	Extra Credit
Day 1	☐ Update study plan post ☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	<u>Complete in order</u> ☐ Slow Game 1 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 1 ☐ Woodpecker Method ☐ Slow Game 2 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 2
Day 2	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 3	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 4	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 5	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 6	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 7	☐ Strategy Review __ min (track time spent)	

If there's still time after the above, add more daily games or slow games.

Week 4

One-quarter of the way done! We will add endgames to the end of this week.

	Base Work	Extra Credit
Day 1	☐ Update study plan post ☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	<u>Complete in order</u> ☐ Slow Game 1 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 1 ☐ Woodpecker Method ☐ Slow Game 2 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 2 <u>Any Order</u> ☐ Opening Review ☐ Endgame Review ☐ Strategy Review ☐ Chess Content If there's still time after the above, add more daily games or slow games.
Day 2	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 3	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 4	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 5	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 6	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 7	☐ Endgame Review __ min (track time spent)	

Week 5

One-third of the way is done! Now would be a good time to compare your ratings to where you started. You should probably see some rating gains already, but if you don't it's OK! Stick with the plan... you've been focused for four weeks already.

	Base Work	Extra Credit
Day 1	☐ Update study plan post ☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	<u>Complete in order</u> ☐ Slow Game 1 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 1 ☐ Woodpecker Method ☐ Slow Game 2 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 2 <u>Any Order</u> ☐ Opening Review ☐ Endgame Review ☐ Strategy Review ☐ Chess Content If there's still time after the above, add more daily games or slow games.
Day 2	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 3	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 4	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 5	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 6	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 7	☐ Woodpecker __ min (track time spent)	

Week 6

Almost to the halfway point! Back to openings at the end of this week.

	Base Work	Extra Credit
Day 1	☐ Update study plan post ☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	<u>Complete in order</u> ☐ Slow Game 1 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 1 ☐ Woodpecker Method ☐ Slow Game 2 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 2 <u>Any Order</u> ☐ Opening Review ☐ Endgame Review ☐ Strategy Review ☐ Chess Content If there's still time after the above, add more daily games or slow games.
Day 2	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games xxxx ☐ Analyze 5+5 games xxxx	
Day 3	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 4	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games xxxx ☐ Analyze 5+5 games xxxx	
Day 5	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 6	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games xxxx ☐ Analyze 5+5 games xxxx	
Day 7	☐ Opening Review __ min (track time spent)	

Week 7

Halfway done! Go check in on the ChessGoals Club and let the members know how you're doing! I hope you are enjoying the Discord community.

	Base Work	Extra Credit
Day 1	☐ Update study plan post ☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	<u>Complete in order</u> ☐ Slow Game 1 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 1 ☐ Woodpecker Method ☐ Slow Game 2 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 2
Day 2	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 3	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 4	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 5	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 6	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 7	☐ Strategy Review ___ min (track time spent)	
		<u>Any Order</u> ☐ Opening Review ☐ Endgame Review ☐ Strategy Review ☐ Chess Content
		If there's still time after the above, add more daily games or slow games.

Week 8

Time for some new endgames this week!

	Base Work	Extra Credit
Day 1	☐ Update study plan post ☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	<u>Complete in order</u> ☐ Slow Game 1 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 1 ☐ Woodpecker Method ☐ Slow Game 2 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 2
Day 2	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 3	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 4	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 5	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 6	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 7	☐ Endgame Review __ min (track time spent)	

If there's still time after the above, add more daily games or slow games.

Week 9

2/3rds of the way done! Keep plugging along and try to get to the extra credit when you have time.

	Base Work	Extra Credit
Day 1	☐ Update study plan post ☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	<u>Complete in order</u> ☐ Slow Game 1 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 1 ☐ Woodpecker Method ☐ Slow Game 2 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 2
Day 2	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 3	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 4	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 5	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 6	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 7	☐ Woodpecker Method ___ min (track time spent)	
		<u>Any Order</u> ☐ Opening Review ☐ Endgame Review ☐ Strategy Review ☐ Chess Content
		If there's still time after the above, add more daily games or slow games.

Week 10

3/4ths of the way done! Finish strong!

	Base Work	Extra Credit
Day 1	☐ Update study plan post ☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	<u>Complete in order</u> ☐ Slow Game 1 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 1 ☐ Woodpecker Method ☐ Slow Game 2 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 2
Day 2	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 3	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 4	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 5	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 6	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 7	☐ Opening Review ___ min (track time spent)	

If there's still time after the above, add more daily games or slow games.

Week 11

	Base Work	Extra Credit
Day 1	☐ Update study plan post ☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	<u>Complete in order</u> ☐ Slow Game 1 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 1 ☐ Woodpecker Method ☐ Slow Game 2 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 2
Day 2	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 3	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 4	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 5	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 6	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 7	☐ Strategy Review __ min (track time spent)	

If there's still time after the above, add more daily games or slow games.

Week 12

Last week!

	Base Work	Extra Credit
Day 1	☐ Update study plan post ☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	<u>Complete in order</u> ☐ Slow Game 1 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 1 ☐ Woodpecker Method ☐ Slow Game 2 ☐ Analyze Slow Game 2
Day 2	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 3	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 4	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 5	☐ Daily games ☐ Play 15+10 Game ☐ Analyze 15+10 Game	
Day 6	☐ Daily games ☐ Play four 5+5 games x x x x ☐ Analyze 5+5 games x x x x	
Day 7	☐ Endgame Review __ min (track time spent)	

If there's still time after the above, add more daily games or slow games.

Congrats, you've completed the 12-week program!

Revisit your ratings from the start of the program and compare them to your current ratings.

How did you do?

Next Steps

- If your rating is >1700 , move to the Advanced Study Plan
- If your rating is <1700 and you enjoy the focused playing, repeat the Adult Improver Intermediate Plan
- If your rating is <1700 and you prefer more time spent studying, try the Yusupov Intermediate Plan or Intermediate Rapid & Classical Plan

Please send me an email (matt@chessgoals.com) and let me know your thoughts on the program. Post your results on the Discord server as well!